Witness Matrix

Credibility × Confidence

CONFIDENCE → / CREDIBILITY ↓	**LOW** “Perhaps.”	**MODERATE** “I think so.”	**HIGH** “I’m fairly sure.”	**CERTAIN** “I’m certain.”
G-HIGH Reliable record. Relevant to this task	A reliable source expresses doubt about this claim. Give the account weight while retaining the doubt. **CREDIBLE · TENTATIVE**	A reliable source leans towards this claim without full certainty. Give the account weight on those terms. **CREDIBLE · MODERATE**	A reliable source expresses high confidence. Give the account weight alongside the evidence for this claim. **CREDIBLE · CONFIDENT**	**BEST VALUE** A reliable source expresses certainty about this claim. Give the account weight alongside the evidence. **CREDIBLE · CERTAIN**
G-MIXED Mixed record. Strengths and failures	The relevant record has strengths and failures, and the source is unsure. Identify what supports this particular account. **CONDITIONAL · TENTATIVE**	The source leans towards the claim, but their record is mixed. Separate the dependable part from the doubtful part. **CONDITIONAL · MODERATE**	High confidence sits beside a mixed record. Check which strengths or failures matter for this claim. **CONDITIONAL · CONFIDENT**	Certainty does not resolve a mixed record. Look for support that addresses the relevant weaknesses. **CONDITIONAL · CERTAIN**
G-UNKNOWN Not yet assessed. Too little basis	The source is unfamiliar and unsure. Examine their access to the event; unfamiliarity alone does not establish unreliability. **UNKNOWN · TENTATIVE**	The source leans towards the claim, but their reliability is not established. Examine what they could know. **UNKNOWN · MODERATE**	The source expresses confidence; credibility remains unassessed. Seek an independent basis for giving the account weight. **UNKNOWN · CONFIDENT**	The source expresses certainty, but little is known about their reliability. Certainty alone settles neither question. **UNKNOWN · CERTAIN**
G-LOW Adverse record. Relevant failures	Relevant failures warrant caution. The source’s doubt does not repair the record, but this account may still be right. **CAUTION · TENTATIVE**	The source leans towards the claim despite a problematic record. Check this account against other evidence. **CAUTION · MODERATE**	Strong confidence does not remove relevant reliability problems. Look for evidence independent of those problems. **CAUTION · CONFIDENT**	**DANGER** Certainty accompanies relevant reliability problems. Do not let emphatic delivery outweigh the need for corroboration. **CAUTION · CERTAIN**

Green: favourable source assessment · Amber: mixed · Blue: unknown · Red: relevant concerns

G = credibility (German: Glaubwürdigkeit). Credibility is task-specific. The Certain-column markers are explained on page 2.

Locate the source here; assess the claim in the Claim Matrix. Explanation: page 2.

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Notes & commentary

Credibility · confidence · the two markers · fair witnessing · using both matrices

Y axis - Credibility

G stands for credibility, from the German Glaubwürdigkeit. Assess the source for this task from a relevant record and the reasons available. Note how that record was checked: being thoroughly tested is not itself a favourable result.

G-high: a relevant reliable record. G-mixed: relevant strengths and failures. G-unknown: too little basis to judge. G-low: relevant reliability failures. CONDITIONAL labels mean weighing the relevant strengths and failures.

Unknown is not low. Familiarity, status, and confident delivery do not establish reliability. A source assessment is revisable; its supporting claims can themselves be checked.

The warning marker - Danger

G-low / Certain combines relevant reliability problems with emphatic certainty. The danger is that decisive delivery may persuade the reader to overlook those problems.

Seek evidence independent of the relevant failure. The marker does not declare dishonesty or automatically reject this particular account; a source with an adverse record can still be right.

An unknown but certain source belongs in G-unknown, not in this warning cell merely for being unfamiliar.

X axis - Stated confidence

The columns describe the certainty the source expresses about this claim. Keep their actual words or number; the example phrases are guides, not a numerical conversion scale.

If confidence is unstated, leave the column unassigned rather than inventing it.

Confidence is not credibility. Greater certainty earns no automatic pass; tentative wording proves neither honesty nor poor reliability. A reliable record does not establish that each confidence statement is calibrated.

From oath to fair witnessing

An honesty pledge asks for truthful reporting. Fair witnessing adds a practical discipline: separate what was observed, inferred, and left unknown.

> I will tell what I know from where I stand.
> I will say how sure I am.
> I will not fabricate.
> I will correct what I learn to be wrong.

A witness can be certain about the visible side of a house without claiming to know its other sides. Precision about scope need not mean uncertainty.

The pledge expresses commitment; the matrices support examination. It does not replace a prescribed legal oath or affirmation.

The positive marker - Best value

G-high / Certain combines a favourable source assessment with an explicit, certain account. The positive marker highlights this favourable source profile: a credible source is speaking with certainty.

Give that account weight alongside the evidence. The marker does not mean certainty makes the source more credible than an equally reliable but cautious witness, or prove that this claim is true.

The green row acknowledges the same favourable relevant record across all four confidence columns.

Use both matrices together

Locate the source here, then assess the claim in the Claim Matrix. Ask which part still depends on this account and what independent support remains.

Readers may disagree about placement. The useful next step is to identify the disputed reason or missing check, not to treat the coloured cell as a verdict.

This is a proposed discussion aid. It has not been validated as a jury instrument; applicable evidentiary rules, burdens of proof, and judicial directions govern any court use.

Same stated certainty; different source records. Neither marker replaces examination of the claim.

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